BOSTON UNIVERSITY / QUESTROM SCHOOL OF BUSINESS

MSBA CHART CHAMP DATATHON

Student challenge brief • November 4–7, 2026

THE CHALLENGE | WIN THE CORPORATE TRAVEL ANALYTICS CONTRACT

A national company relies on frequent employee air travel. Delays and cancellations disrupt meetings, reduce productivity, and generate unexpected expenses. Your team is an analytics consulting firm responding to a request for proposals (RFP): use flight-performance data to identify practical ways the client can reduce disruption while balancing travel cost, convenience, and business needs.

YOUR OBJECTIVES

Identify meaningful patterns in flight reliability; quantify relevant risks and trade-offs; and recommend specific, defensible changes to the client's travel policy or booking practices. You may use descriptive statistics, predictive models, segmentation, or other appropriate methods—explain why your approach fits the business problem.

DATA & SCOPE

Core data: U.S. Bureau of Transportation Statistics (BTS), Reporting Carrier On-Time Performance. All teams receive the same starting dataset of domestic flights. Optional enrichment: NOAA historical weather, airport characteristics, or other documented public sources. External data and sophisticated models are optional—not required. Document your assumptions and data limitations.

WHAT TO SUBMIT / PRESENT

- A concise client-facing presentation with clear visualizations and 2–4 prioritized recommendations.
- Evidence supporting your conclusions, including analytical method, validation where appropriate, and key limitations.
- A brief explanation of implementation considerations and how the client could measure success.
- Be ready to defend your decisions and respond to a hypothetical business constraint during Q&A.

EVALUATION CRITERIA

Business relevance & actionable recommendations	30%
Analytical rigor & methodology	30%
Data visualization & storytelling	25%
Critical thinking, limitations & live Q&A	15%

SCHEDULE

Wed, Nov 4 — Challenge brief and core dataset released. Fri, Nov 6 — Independent team work. Sat, Nov 7, 2:00–4:00 p.m. — Live presentations and judging at Questrom (third floor; check-in details to follow).

Judges will reward sound reasoning and useful recommendations—not simply the most complex model or polished dashboard.